our footsteps amongst the stars

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by catnip (bearmons)

Summary

Adora has always struggled with her position of power, or lack thereof. A Princess by title, blood and birthright. She had the power to do so much but yet so little.

The paradox of such a status comes to her knowledge early on in childhood. And somehow, it started and will only continue to grow where Catra is concerned.

A growth that danced between them as they transverse their roles in the established pecking order of the eyes of their society, and what it meant for them. As with age came more expectations and repercussions.

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OR: she was a princess, she was a servant, can I make it any more obvious?
There may be some yearning, what more can I say?

Notes

too many words, bare minimum editing attempts made - we rawdogging this royalty au.

See the end of the work for more notes

The jitters are gone. Floating between the space of the twinkling stars and dancing crystals of the lake, Adora cannot stifle her giggle when she threads her small fingers between Catra's. They were basking in a canvas of grey-blue, the sun having retired long ago, but as they huddled under the shelter of a tree's busty crown, they teetered between its dark shadows and the reflection of the moonlight off the lake's surface. Her evening gown sweeps at her ankles, threatening to trip her, but she stumbles through the motion anyways. They sway around a bit, feet awkward and steps uncoordinated. Head down and eyes concentrated on their feet, Adora tries to count the steps like she had learned in her lessons. However, no matter how hard she tries, the rhythm escapes her.

"Here," was it strange that she could hear Catra's smile within her words? She halts and Adora falls into her. Fingers slipping out of hers, they catch each other by their waists. Again, it rips an echoing laughter from her. Instead of being berated for her clumsiness, shame doesn't hit her but joy instead as she nuzzles into the warmth of Catra's shoulder. "This should do it," Catra's voice is directly breathed into her ear before Adora feels herself being lifted up with what felt like no effort at all to stand on Catra's feet.

"Wait," she fumbles back. Because she doesn't want to hurt Catra. And because her father had stopped coming to see her after her lessons, and maybe that was a sign that she was a big girl now, and big girls no longer get lifted to stand on dancing feet.

"You were going to step on me, anyways," Catra shakes her head, finding her bashfulness ridiculous.

"No, I wasn't," Adora pouts.

Catra doesn't give her the satisfaction of another thrown jab, she instead leans back to flash her a gummy grin. Amusement swims within her eyes, and at the right angle of the moonlight hitting her, they glow of rich melting honey surrounded by the brightness

of the highest sun and of cloudless skies on a sunny day. Adora could marvel at them endlessly.

Without another word, she moves and takes Adora with her.

Her movement starts slow at first, possibly to get Adora used to the fact that she's being carried by her much smaller friend. She teeters here and there, trying to find her centre of gravity, before deciding to just lean back in and clutch more firmly to the body in her grasp. That is when Catra begins to really move.

Her steps are purposeful. Feet sweep the dirt beneath them in as long of strides that her stubby legs can reach. With her chin caught in the little nook between Catra's shoulder and neck, Adora watches the world dance around them.

She wonders, as Catra dances for the both of them, how the girl knew how to. Adora was the one who took lessons. She was the one being prepped with ball gowns, etiquettes, and different formal dances. But Catra, sweet Catra with her scruffy hair that didn't know which direction it was meant to stick, in her hemp trousers tied thrice around her miniscule waist with twine, utterly consumed by her large, once white, tattered linen shirt, easily takes Adora's whole weight on scuffed leather boots, drifting through the night like they were in a ballroom.

"How do you know how to dance?"

Her cheek moves with the shrug of Catra's shoulders. "I always wanted to know what you were doing in that big room." Small arms pull her in just that bit more, her voice falling to a whisper, gaps of air between her breath allowing for the calm laps of the lake water to sing through. "You come out looking upset all the time. Wanted to see if I could help."

Embarrassed or shy, Adora doesn't know which she's feeling, or if it's a mixture of both. Catra must have seen her clomp her way through her lessons, sometimes she actually did trip and fall, then the long scoldings she'd receive afterwards. Catra saw it all. Saw

the way her face turned from pink of shame to a deep red of upset. But here she is, not pointing out Adora's misgivings, but instead, trying to teach her the best way she could.

Just being here - being swayed within her arms - seemed more than enough for Adora. Where they moved to the symphony of nature.

"Princess Adora!"

The calm around them shatters louder than a porcelain vase hitting the ground. Adora hadn't the time to unbury herself from Catra before the girl was yanked from her arms. The sudden startle quickly vanishes, leaving way for concern to ripple through her, the words flying at her goes through one ear and out the other, as she sees Catra being thrusted back and away from her. Her small body flounders to catch itself, but Adora sees her skid across the dirt ground before rolling over the edge between land and water.

Such carelessness. No respect. Adora sees red but Catra looks up at her, almost like she recognises the shift in her expression, and shakes her head. Like a silent command or plea, Catra could easily read her emotions and where those rising tempers would take her. No, she can't have a tantrum. No, it apparently is never worth it to stand up for how Catra is treated. For someone who holds so much power within her tiny hands, when she tries to use them to right the wrongs of others around her, she never understands how it never works. How pointing out mistreatment somehow causes it to increase in its viciousness.

You're a child, Adora. You don't understand how the world works, yet.

That cynical voice in her head starts again. In a whispered tone that travels high and shrill, Adora always imagines that that was what a witch would sound like. She only firms up on that comparison due to the fact that it was her etiquette instructor's voice, and that lady was far too nasty for someone teaching her

what manners a young lady should grace. The answers she gets to her questions from her instructor always leaves a bitter taste in her mouth.

In a societal hierarchy, where Catra is physically within arm's reach from her but a thousand miles away from where she's perched up on her lavish throne, they cannot be seen this informal together. Her friend is not even allowed to look at her within the castle walls.

Maybe that's why they sneak out to the edges of the woods. Where no eyes admonished upon them. Just small woodland creatures, the calm lake, and the stars and the moon.

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She doesn’t know how far she’s walked, just that the music has become duller to the sound of the howling wind surrounding her. Adora needed to get out of there. The ballroom was vast, fitting in more people than she’s ever seen in one room. Could and shouldn’t probably ever be able to fit in one room. It made her feel tight, like the more her eyes took in the more it stole the breath from her concaving chest.

A large gust blows harsh upon her, and with her billowing gown that she not only detested from first sight, but also despised how it wore her down, she can feel herself on the verge of being lifted right off her feet as its weight and the heavy wind threatens to topple her over. The noise of the large gathering is but tiny prickles to her ears if she strains to listen. The distance must be far enough of a refuge that she no longer has to continue her escape.

The stables just up ahead now screams of luxury just like anything else found within the castle walls. Its structure is large and grand, only fitting for some of the kingdom’s most esteemed stallions. They were hand picked and bred to be the biggest, strongest and fastest within the land.

Adora was promised one of her own for her upcoming birthday. The grey period in her life, marking her transition from a girl to a lady. Lessons will only come by more often, and the intricacies that she was already muddling up will only become more convoluted. Like, which hand to put atop the other when sitting down, or which nod and wave was appropriate to whom was in her presence and the occasion.

If anyone were to ask Adora, anyone who didn't intimidate the stockings right from her feet, she'd say this was all stupid and a waste of time. But, no one ever asked Adora for her opinion if not on which colour gown she wanted to wear for the day or what new subjects took her curiosity more.

Maybe this will all be worth it when she gets her own horse.

Pushing one of the stable's wooden doors, she heaves enough of a gap to let herself slink in. She didn't want to risk letting the wind blow it wide open and having no possible way to fight it on top of the door's extravagant weight to close it up again.

Almost like cushioning the entirety of the space inside, hay littered every surface of ground, in the far corners, and packed up the second floor were rectangular stacks of them. Oil-lit lanterns sat along the walls, keeping the place a warm yellow, its light bouncing off the natural tan of the hay.

It was like walking into another world. From the blinding brightness of the ballroom with too many vibrant coloured gowns for her eyes to fully digest, to the dark, unforgiving coldness of outside to this. Adora hadn't frequented the stables in a long time. Not since her father started cooping himself up in the throne room, meeting travellers from across many seas. Especially not since she stopped sneaking out into the night with -

"Adora?"

Head popping up from one of the dividers, Adora recognised her friend's raspy voice that had only begun to deepen and fray at

times as of recent years, before her eyes could squint enough to see the defining features that uniquely painted Catra from others. Her hair is tied into a low ponytail, recently clobbered short as it was getting everywhere. The ends were barely being kept in the red ribbon Catra had charmed from one of the kitchen maids, reminding Adora of those stumpy brushes she now saw ladies use to powder their faces with. Even when she tried to tidy her unruly head of hair, Catra still somehow managed to have multiple sticks of hay poking out from different areas. That sight alone has a smile threatening to emerge. Adora hasn't seen her friend for a couple of days, but it has been months since the two of them have been in the stables together.

The last ended in punishment ordered upon Catra when they had come out here to pet and brush the horses, only for one of the new stallions which wasn't familiar with either of them to stomp on Adora's foot. Catra was older now, and with that so did her punishments in its severity.

An order of flogging. Five lashes, as an introduction and warning.

Adora had snuck some of her ointment the royal physician had given her to lather on her swollen foot. Apparently it promoted fast healing. Catra certainly needed it more than her. Adora didn't know who cried more during that time. Catra, who choked back her sobs at the lightest of touch or brush of air, or Adora, seeing the aftermath of what her simple friendship could do. Nothing she has ever seen before was this terrifyingly red and angry.

Catra switched to wearing black linen shirts after that. Less washings needed if no evidence of her pain could be seen seeping through.

"What are you doing here?"

It came to no surprise to Adora to see her friend sitting on one of the stallion's backs with such ease. They learnt how to climb a horse together, but Adora's anxiousness of being so high off the ground and climbing a body of firm muscle seemed to rub off on

the horses. Maybe that's how and why she got stomped on. Her nervous energy probably poured out from her that night.

Catra was a natural around animals though, horses no less.

"What happened to your face?" Adora ignores her friend's question outright to zero on the fact that her right eyebrow has a fresh split - framed by blotches of crusted blood - running diagonally across it, the eye under it sporting blossoms of black and deep purple, so swollen that it hid the beauty that was her eye - of layered depths of blue which she knew would have held its own small universes within it in such a lighting they were in right now - now sealed shut beneath it. The sight of it brought a heavy frown to her lips.

"Oh," Catra has the audacity to give her an easy grin. Like this was normal or a funny story. But now that Adora thinks about it, maybe - unfortunately - it was something normal for Catra.

Adora loathes the thought of it being that way.

"Curiosity killed the cat," she shrugs, smiling still intact. "Picked up a knight's sword just to see if I could when I was running them their fresh wash cloths. Who knew the hilt of one could hurt probably as much as its blade."

Adora takes a step back, adamant to right a wrong. "I'm getting my ointment," she announces, then turns to leave.

The scuffle of hay comes from behind her before she hears the whining of the hinges as Catra opens the stall's little gate. "Adora, really, it's fine," Adora's swinging hand was caught behind her. Her resolve must have been miniscule, because something as small as Catra holding her hand stops her right in her tracks.

"It's not *fine* ." She spits.

"Yeah, well," Catra lets go of her hand, and that somehow makes her feel even worse. Adora turns on her spot and feels the frustration that was bubbling in her fizzle away. Catra is hugging

herself at the waist now, almost like she's consoling herself, her light grin now sheepish. Once again, she shrugs. "There's nothing we can do about it."

And the feeling comes back tenfold. Because she should be able to. It's within her birthright to rule over lands and her kingdom, so why can't she define what is right and what is wrong? Why is she instead supposed to be gallivanting in that ballroom right now, as if there aren't dire changes that need her tending to?

"Why are you here, Adora?"

Why is she here? Why would she rather stay in a building that smells thick of animals and their excrements, head throbbing from a concoction of emotions from the mere sight of *another* injury inflicted upon her friend, than to twirl and curtsy for show in a well-lit, fully catered ballroom?

"The courting has commenced."

Adora's voice sounds foreign to herself. She doesn't even acknowledge herself saying those words. The need to distance herself from such thought and reality is automatic within her.

Confusion washes over Catra's face, swimming down from the furrow of her brows, the little wrinkle of her nose, to the slight frown sliding over her lips. "Oh," is all she whispers. Then, a beat passes between them, before she lets out a sigh, so heavy Adora physically sees it lazing out the tenseness of her body. "No one tickling your fancy?" Catra has that grin on her face, a lopsided one bordering on a smirk, that drives skitters up Adora's back. It always has.

"Not in the slightest." Adora sniffs, turning her nose up more of a show of petulance, to distract herself and avoid that stupid look on Catra's face.

"Ah, not one suitor was bestowed your hand?"

Adora would never do such a thing. Accepting a hand of dance was just as good as sealing her future away to someone. It showed interest if anything, but in this game of flirting showmanship and creating family ties, it was the beginning of the next stage in her life that she never wanted to happen. Not without her own, honest, say in it.

Catra takes her silence as a good enough answer. "Well, then, Princess Adora," turning back to look at her friend, she instantly recognises her stance. Left arm behind her back with the back of her hand curling around her waist, she has her right arm lifted vertically skyward, slightly towards Adora, palm open and presented, waiting for her acceptance. She has that infuriating grin again, her head tilted up so she could still look at her in her slightly lowered bow.

"May I have this dance?"

The offer is there, Adora's seen and heard enough of it tonight. But there is no hidden agenda masked behind a practised smile. No words of fancy possessions and false compliments. Just an easy grin, amusement swimming in a twinkling non-swollen eye, and a silent promised bond of endearment and companionship.

Unlike the entire night, Adora doesn't hesitate. She doesn't fully curtsy to show rejection of the offer. She instead lifts her own right arm and gently lines it up with Catra's, placing her open palm against hers. She grabs her gown with her left hand and returns Catra's bow with her own slight dip of a curtsy. Catra straightens up when she does, and that playful grin now spreads to a dazzling one, fully across her lips, and up her cheeks to curve around her eyes.

This smile always takes her breath away.

Adora can never find it in herself to not smile back.

It's almost like muscle memory as Catra leads her into the beginning of the dance, and Adora follows her until the very end.

“Do I want to know how you know this dance?”

Catra only chuffs out a short laugh. “I have my ways.”

“I’m sure you do,” she rolls her eyes.

If she strains to listen, she could still hear the noise of the large gathering prickling in her ears. So instead, Adora lets the sweeping of Catra’s feet against the hay covered ground, the howling wind against the wooden structure of the stable, and the nickers of the horses within their stalls be the only music to her ears.

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The earth wobbled under her feet, with every step she had to adjust her weight and squint to catch the ground before it ran from her. It felt as if the breeze blew the world a blur before her eyes, with the sturdy structures and heavy tree trunks tilting and scattering.

She doesn’t know when the night turned so dark, and when instead of her glass she now had a bottle in her hand. The gathering, a celebration of some sort that no one gave her privy to, was well on its way. Laughter combated the music, and it’s only when Adora has ventured far enough into the royal gardens that she hears her own break off into slight giggles and hiccups, until nothing is left but the puffs of her breathing and the rustling leaves.

Today was a good day, she wants to say. It was one of the first gatherings that didn’t leave her feeling all coiled up inside. Maybe, because for the first time, she had some company that was warranted. She would never admit it aloud, but Adora is grateful that she had to befriend the other princesses from nearby kingdoms.

Officially, it was to strengthen her own by having alliances. But unofficially, Adora was able to actually have friends who understood some of her grievances. Many sought for the power

that was within their grasp but unable to utilise, while others wanted their own and more. It was interesting, to say the least, to be able to see how everyone else dealt with their own problems and status. It gave her a better perspective, even if she still had yet the courage to voice her own honestly.

A few of the princesses had attended the gathering, and Adora stuck to them. Surrounded within a small group of them, suitors were less likely to approach her. Lest they were ready to be rejected by her in front of some of the most powerful figures of the surrounding seas, or worse, lose her possible hand and the possibility of trying their luck in gaining the other princesses'.

Adora thinks it's safe to assume that through the events of the gathering, her bond with the others only strengthened. She danced, she laughed, she gossiped. And that was more than enough socialising for Adora. For someone who had her companions cherry picked since she could remember, she only had so much energy and will to converse with others and be in their presence before she was mentally drained.

That's why, when another round of dancing was called, she had politely declined. Though she had thought she grabbed her glass but instead somehow obtained a bottle, she had decided to seek some alone time out in the garden. It could be the liquor now swimming alongside her blood within her veins, but Adora knows she should be feeling the prickle of the cold draft instead of the warmth radiating off her skin.

The music may be muffled now, behind the closed doors, but they still sing to her ears, and she blames the mood a drop of wine always gives her, because before she knows it, she's swaying to the strings.

She follows down the pebbled path, taking the hand of the breeze as she twirls and glides her feet along the ground, her gown of gold pleats on white silk billowing like a dome. She's running out of breath trying to see how long she can keep the bottom of her

gown afloat, missing her chances to take in air by prioritising her giggles and sips from the bottle.

By the time she's reached the plot of roses, Adora is properly out of breath. Head tilted back, she takes large gulps greedily, and with every exhale she returns back puffs of misty clouds into the atmosphere.

The treetops fissle, but if Adora closes her eyes, she can imagine the leaves that clutter against one another clapping for her performance. She smiles at the thought. And maybe her mind was more powerful at concocting such an illusion, because she actually begins to hear real applause.

"My, Princess, you do put on a magnificent show."

If it were from anyone else, especially from the gathering, Adora would have been offended. And rightly so, because the tone was dripping in almost arrogance, and from anyone else, it would not have sat right with her. But, sitting atop a thick branch high off the ground, back against the trunk with one leg bent while the other swayed off the branch and lazily with the wind, was Catra.

Arrogant was Catra's default attitude as of recently. The two of them haven't been within each other's orbit quite as often lately, due to her having to play more into her exceedingly growing role, and well, whatever it is Catra has been getting herself into.

However, as she stares up at her old friend, she notices some changes that have taken shape. The wildness of her hair is under control now, out of her face with no earth seen sticking out or stuck within, and from down here, it looks to be tied into a bun behind her head. Her black linen shirt has stayed, but under it she must be wearing a shirt so rich in red, it almost seems crimson, as she sees the long sleeves that extend from under where the black linen cuts off. Replacing the hemp trousers are now figure fitting black ones, running down her slender legs before being hidden by boots tied tight to her ankles.

Adora wants to question the new clothes, but what catches her eyes the most is what's draped over her shoulders. A doublet, of fine white and gold trimmings. Something burns in her, seeing it on Catra, of all people, because only certain people own those tailor made jackets. Certain people that, when Adora last checked, Catra was not.

A General in her Royal Army.

"Calm down, Princess. Glare at me any harder and you'll set me on fire." Everything Catra says comes off playful, and when she leaps off her spot from the high tops, she lands with such grace Adora could never fathom to muster. There's that grin again, but as they age, it just becomes more infuriating to see. Because Catra seems to have started to pick up on what that smile does to the people around her, so she wears it like a deadly weapon. And when coupled with the refinement of her speech pattern, vocabulary and choice of wording, she can easily see it causing mass destruction to whoever it was aimed at. "It's not mine," she lifts her left arm up from the currently crossed position it was in with the other, once hidden within the shadowy confinements of the draped jacket, to poke her hand out to play with the fraying gold thread of the lining.

That knowledge doesn't help dampen the flames within her. Maybe she has had too much wine and it's giving her heart burn.

The grin only deepens, showing off more of her teeth and putting her canines that almost glints in the moonlight on full display, at Adora's silence. "Someone doesn't seem taken by that idea either. Would you like to have it instead?" Catra goes to shrug off the jacket, but Adora is starting to despise the sight of it the longer she stares, so she doesn't know what she'd do if Catra were to actually give it to her.

She'll explode at the mere touch of it, perhaps.

Instead of draping it over her shoulders, Catra instead turns the jacket around. Whatever curse or spiteful words she had in her

head for the owner of the jacket runs cold when it is revealed that there's a large hole through the back of it.

"Heard a cannon got 'em during the last voyage the kingdom took. Went clean through, from the rumours, and well, the gaping hole." Catra lets the jacket fall from her hold, the fabric now catching at the hook of her two fingers.

"That still does not explain why you're wearing it."

"They have yet to make me my own, and since I scored the highest, this was my prize." Catra lets her sentence float off, shrugging as if Adora knew where she was going with it. The realisation that Adora hadn't the slightest clue as to what Catra was talking about had her looking at her oldest, first ever non-cherry picked, genuine friend with new eyes. It wasn't just her clothing that had changed, it seemed.

Reading Catra's mind was something Adora used to be good at. Sometimes, it was like they could communicate without words whatsoever. The little twitches of her eyebrows, the widening of her pupils, or even what the different smiles she wore meant. Adora could just look at Catra and within a few seconds know so much. But now, with less time spent together, gaps within their lives not shared, she's beginning to feel that ability slip between her fingers.

And it's not only her who knows, because Catra only sighs softly at her lack of response. It's a light puff of air that escapes her, and Adora stares at the little cloud it forms, and as it fades and dissipates away within the thin space separating them, she thinks that something that was so innate and special between them was lost within it as well.

"Well," Catra reaches up and behind her head, grabbing at something before giving it a tug and quickly after it is the flow of her long hair, pouring down and over her shoulders. It's a magnificent sight to behold, slight waves like calm, rippling water that Adora can still see in the back of her eyelids, the silky texture

running over her fingertips as she'd brush the tangles and knots out. It frames Catra's face just right, accentuating her features that only grow more bold and sightly with time. Adora's staring is broken when something reflects the moonlight right into her eyes.

Presented within her grasp is an arrow broken in half, Catra's thumb stroking the blade of the head as if it couldn't easily slice right through her skin. She has a grin that is so full as she stares at the armoury with exuding pride, it spreads over her entire face and up her cheeks. Catra is absolutely glowing.

Mind running through millions of possible reasons, Adora tries to connect the jacket, the proud smile, and the weapon in hand. And then something clicks into place. "You passed the entrance." It comes out like an awestruck whisper from her lips and carried off with the wind.

"I passed," Catra's smile widens impossibly so.

"I didn't even know you were learning archery."

Catra shrugs, "Time easily slips these days."

Adora is given a small smile, and she knows Catra is giving her an out. That between the two of them, and the heavily contrasting lives they live, maybe knowing what the other person is doing every second of their day was just not plausible anymore. And with the delicate eyes trained upon her, Adora feels some sense of hope blossom from somewhere deep within when she finds that she is still able to see as clear as day that Catra isn't mad. That she's understanding of their differences. And that they're still okay.

Maybe some things don't change.

A sudden blast of strings and chatter storms the silence they were in, and Adora is reminded of where she was before Catra had easily taken her entire attention and surroundings. The gentle

look is gone from Catra's face, as if with an open door also came the arrival of her exceedingly growing elfin demeanour.

"Well, Princess, as you were," she says with a dashing lopsided grin.

"As I were?" She's confuddled by her wording.

"Why, your spectacular show just for my eyes, of course."

Adora bumbles out a surprised laugh, because how arrogant of Catra to say such a thing. "Presumptuous for you to assume it was for you."

"But Princess," Catra steps into her personal space, and as her voice drops to that of almost a whisper, her words bounce within what little gap sits between them. The warmth radiating off of Catra and travelling with her voice burns at Arora's skin. "I believe I deserve some sort of celebration." Her arms reach up to circle around her, forearms resting comfortably on her shoulders, enveloping Adora in a light embrace, and for a split second it's a different type of warmth that encases her. All of her senses overload as it takes in Catra. From her scent of wood saw and grass, the low lull of her decadent raspy voice that now swings and swoops as it licks and curls teasingly around the lilt that now embeds every nuance and intonation of her arsenal of charged words, to her fingertips gliding down the expanse of the slope of Adora's shoulders as she wraps the forgotten, once offending, doublet over her. And just like that, after she's barely breathed in everything of the blooming woman in front of her, Catra steps back.

A beat passes before Adora decides to take up the challenge. She brings the bottle of wine to her lips and takes in a large gulp. It's only Catra, Adora reminds herself, so when some liquor dribbles over her chin, she catches it with the back of her hand, lifts her brows right back at Catra's twitching amused ones, and then she begins to twirl.

Adora spins and steps to the beat of Catra's clapping hands, and as the world returns to blurring around her, she can still clearly see Catra and only Catra. She keeps her eyes on the woman as the boulder to her out of control whirl, lest she want to become sick.

A lot has certainly changed between the two of them, but something that is constant, and Adora wishes to never change, is for Catra to remain by her side. For this dance of theirs to remain just so.

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When morning comes after her little show in the garden for Catra's eyes and amusement only, Adora's working brain will drown in the realisation that a change so little had slipped from her radar. But something this little meant the world to her.

A heaviness sits upon her chest as it dawns and settles within her, so great it keeps her rooted to her mattress, clenching and gouging itself between her ribs.

When did Catra stop calling her by her name and only by her title?

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The night was unending. Adora has already seen the bottom of the first bottle she and Glimmer had swiped from the table. As the sister of the recently crowned, and now wedded King, it was mandatory for her to attend each and every ceremony, celebration, and whatever other debauchery her brother had schemed up. The first few she did fine. But it was these ones that ran through the night, until the sun kissed the land as it rose, while she still had yet to lay any rest that rattled her bones.

Adora was beyond *exhausted* . With every gathering the longer they ran and the more chaotic the guests became. Lucky for her, tonight's one Glimmer had been able to make. What with the long journey at sea, she had unfortunately, for Adora, missed all of the

previous ones. Needing alone time but also company, however much that doesn't make sense, Adora had Glimmer in one hand, a bottle in the other, and climbed them both up to the thrones placed up against the back wall. Here, she was less likely to be disturbed. However, this was also where she was given a high vantage view of the party.

"Stare harder, perhaps you'll make it less obvious." The humour in Glimmer's voice carries through with her tinkling laugh. She's slouched on Adora's assigned throne, Adora sitting on her brother's because he would never kick her off it, chin resting on her closed fist, smirking right at her.

"I don't know what you're inferring." She clears her throat to hide the squeak of being caught.

Whereas Adora has been intrigued with their law system since a young age, her brother Adam has been a fanatic of war. He was fascinated with the strategy of battles ever since he could hold a wooden sword. And as the King and groom of this week-long celebration, he had invited their kingdom's entire army to join in.

And with that came a woman dressed in a fitted black doublet with pleats of vibrant red lining it. Her entire attire was of slender black, worn like a second skin, sans for the one horned mask that runs diagonally across her face, as per the theme her brother had wanted. If Adora didn't already know who was behind that mask, the unobstructed side of her face that gave way for the flecks of freckles kissing across a high cheekbone, and above that an eyebrow cut in two from a jagged scar obtained in her adolescent years, revealed her identity.

Or perhaps it was only Adora who knew those intimate details.

From her seat, she had seen Catra's arrival. Watched her unclip from her lapel and shrug off the chocolate fur thrown over her left shoulder to hand off at the door, before gracing the floor like she naturally belonged amongst the royals. Back straight and gaze forward, her shoulders stretched out wide, grown and built from

years in their cavalry unit. It wasn't only Adora's attention she had garnered, though. And with every approach the woman had from a guest, Adora’s stare became unknowingly harder, every pull from the bottle a little longer, travel slightly harder as it had to pass her clenched teeth.

All unknown to everyone but Glimmer, it seems.

"You know, Bow has a matching outfit."

That pulls Adora out from her embarrassment and her watchful eyes of some Lady of a House or whatever's hand in Catra's and on her shoulder as they danced. Glimmer isn't looking at her anymore. Her cheek now resting in her open palm, she's openly staring at the man she mentioned. In the exact same uniform as Catra's, he instead has a mask identical to hers but running diagonally on the other side of his face, and where her doublet was of black and red, Bow was of white and lavender.

Glimmer wears a gentle smile, eyes so warm, Adora doesn't know if it was the wine that has the tops of her cheek splashed in a light pink or if it was the mere sight of Bow. She met him a few times when she visited Glimmer kingdom. The two of them reminded Adora of her and Catra.

Bow’s parents are respected philosophers of the royal court. And as such, Glimmer had grown up acquainted with them until they became her closest mentors. Hence, she also grew up around Bow as well, who stuck to his parents like a shadow. Unlike his parents, or his older siblings, he veered from the family's long line of scholars to become an archer in Glimmer’s royal army. His upbringing gives him an unmatched tenderness to almost everything he does, but that never stops him from laying an arrow in anything from farther than the eye can see.

What Adora didn't personally know about the man, her friend willingly divulged with gleeful enthusiasm like a story passed down from the ages.

It's in this knowledge and understanding that Adora lets herself peep over from her built up walls. If anyone could relate to her it would be Glimmer.

"Is it hard?"

How a short sigh could hold so much sorrow and want, Adora felt it leave Glimmer and settle somewhere deep in her own muscles. "Sometimes it's so hard I can't even think."

Adora slumps back into her seat, winded. She sweeps her eyes across the floor until they settle back on her oldest friend, and the bane of her every waking minute. And on most nights, her dreams as well. She doesn't know when these thoughts began occurring. Doesn't remember when she started searching for Catra in every crowd. When or why her mind would leave her current situation to venture off, as if led by a string, back to Catra and always Catra.

Adora doesn't know when, but one day it became more, until more became always and now Catra is all that encompasses her every thought.

"Does it get easier?" Adora dares to ask.

"When I'm with him, I forget just for a second that I can't have him. And when I'm not? All I do is wait for when I can."

Can Adora do that? Can she want Catra the way she does? The way her mind screams for her, the burning sensation upon her skin from being in the mere presence of her, or the ache of her muscles begging to just reach out that bit more for the lightest of touch. If Adora admits that she wants Catra the way she does, then what? Can she wait? And for what, exactly?

How can Adora wait for something that can never happen.

There is not one second that goes by that Adora doesn't know that she cannot have Catra the way she can only dream of.

That in her dreams she can openly be the new Lady now within Catra's arms. Shamelessly flaunting to the entire room, for all eyes to see, that she chose Catra to dance with. That in a room full of such powerful people, she chose Catra to hold her.

In her dreams, Catra holds her and Adora never lets go.

"Is it worth it?" She needs to know.

"Every second I get with him blankets the endless agony I am without."

She lets the words wash over her, too unsure of how to comprehend such sentiments that she's beginning to realise she too feels.

"And is she?" Glimmer asks in return.

When eyes of ocean blue and liquid gold catches hers, Adora's heart unclenches. With the rise of a toothy grin no amount of mask can ever fathom to hide, Adora's lips automatically lift as well. Such small actions, but they move mountains from within her with such ease.

But is such violent emotions worth it? To have someone be able to have such total control over her with only a smile as their weapon?

The litany of indecisive voices of what ifs is drowned out by the only answer she knows ever existed when it came to Catra. She can find a million reasons to negate it, but this is one thought she had carried with her ever since she could remember.

With an even tone, Adora answers Glimmer without a second to spare or think. Because it has always been Catra. "She's the air I breathe." Adora's eyes never leave Catra. Never seem to ever be able to when they share the same space. How the way she holds herself, how she presents herself to other people, even how she dances, Adora will never not be left in awe with the ways in which Catra only becomes more graceful and beautiful with time. With a

chest so full yet incomprehensibly tight, Adora can only watch from her throne, as if the expanse between the two of them measured the distance of the largest seas. "Without, I suffocate. Every breath drawn I savour and hold until the next I can take."

They stay in understanding silence for the rest of the night, declining every hand offered because the ones they want are not allowed to approach them. When her bottle runs dry and Glimmer has retired back to her room, readying for the journey home at dawn, Adora cannot watch another woman approach Catra, and leaves.

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That night she did not dance.

But in her dreams - in her wildest but most reoccurring dreams Catra is unmasked, her hair finally let down once more, wild like a net trapping in all types of nature to nestle a home within the strands. She sweeps her off of her feet and into her arms, and Adora cannot do much else but drown in her. Adora holds her breath, savouring in this moment and lets herself get taken under the spell that Catra has casted over her for what feels like more years than she’s ever lived.

Because in that moment, in her dreams where there is no whisper of all the rules and expectations that constrict and confine her, defining the boundaries of her desires, Adora is unburdened. Unbound.

They both are.

End Notes

cannot say if this was even close to a happy ending, open ending nor even bittersweet... but tadaaa~

if anyone has somehow read this story before: i had edited this story into another pairing and posted it a few years back, but it was written for catradora and dynamics catered for them. only felt right that i post this story for the original characters it was written for

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